

Policy Memo | Why Limiting Climate Change Matters for Niger

To: Minister of Environment, Head of Niger’s UNFCCC delegation	From: KOUAME Koffi Fidèle, Climate Adviser
Date: 14 October 2026	Subject: What Niger stands to lose, and gains if warming is limited

Key message

Under current global policies, days of dangerous heat in Niger would triple by 2100, from about 31 a year to 91; holding warming below 2 °C would cap them at about 42. In a country where farming and herding employ over 80 % of workers, mostly outdoors, this is the largest avoidable loss. Severe drought, however, spreads to almost the whole territory by 2030 in every scenario: **Niger must press for a rapid global phase-out of emissions and secure finance to adapt now.**

1. Why the stakes are high

Agriculture and livestock generate almost 40 % of GDP and depend overwhelmingly on rainfall (World Bank, 2024). Shocks are already deadly: the 2024 floods killed 339 people and affected more than 1.1 million (AFP, 2024). Yet Niger’s share of global emissions is negligible, so its losses can only be limited by others’ cuts.

2. Three priority impacts in 2100: below 2 °C versus current policies

Impact (CIE indicator)	Today (2020)	Below 2 °C	Current policies	Why it matters for Niger
Dangerous heat <i>Days/year, heat index >40 °C</i>	31 [25–38]	42 [29–72]	91 [59–134]	Outdoor work becomes hazardous; the rise is twice as large in the populated south as in the north. WASCAL researchers project heat discomfort for over half of West Africans at 1.5–2 °C (Sylla et al., 2018).
Severe drought <i>Land with ≥1 month of SPEI < −1.5</i>	84 % [72–97]	98 % [81–100]	100 % [98–100]	Heat dries soils and pastures: about 96 % of the land is affected by 2030 in every scenario. Millet yields are projected to fall (Mohamed et al., 2025).
Extreme rainfall <i>Max. 5-day rain, change from 1995–2014</i>	+8 % [−7, +29]	+17 % [−1, +54]	+43 % [+5, +110]	Floods hit Niamey and the river valley; extreme Sahelian storms have tripled since 1982 (Taylor et al., 2017).

Source: *Climate Impact Explorer*, Niger, annual, area-weighted; NGFS scenarios (1.6 °C and 2.9 °C of global warming in 2100). Median of five models, 5–95 % range in brackets; results after 2060 are indicative.

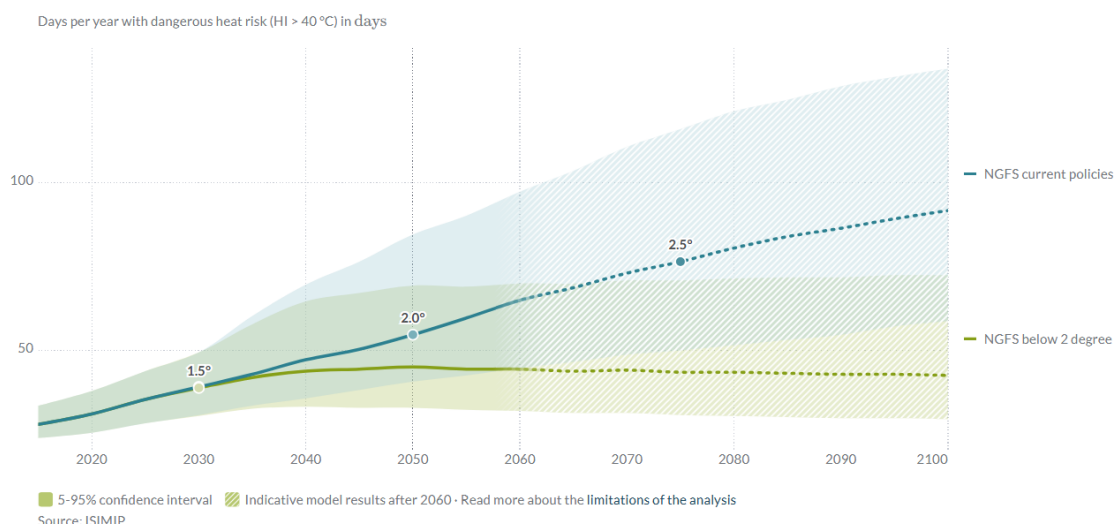


Figure 1. Days of dangerous heat per year in Niger: the gap between the curves is what limiting warming saves. The pathways diverge after 2030; even the low end of the current-policies range in 2100 (59 days) exceeds the central below-2 °C estimate (42). Source: [Climate Impact Explorer](#), Climate Analytics.

3. What limiting warming would change for Niger

A below-2 °C world would spare Niger about 49 days of dangerous heat a year by 2100 and cut the intensification of extreme rainfall from +43 % to +17 %; a 1.5 °C pathway would keep heat near today's level (32 days). Climate change could reduce annual GDP by 2.2 % to 11.9 % by 2050 ([World Bank, 2022](#)). Drought, by contrast, becomes the norm in every scenario, which makes adaptation urgent: drought-tolerant millet and sorghum, water harvesting, early warning and protected herder mobility. The real danger is a cascade: a hot, dry year → failed harvests and pastures → higher grain prices and distress sales of livestock → malnutrition, debt and farmer–herder tensions → emergency spending that crowds out investment.

Recommended negotiating position

- (i) Defend the 1.5 °C goal and NDCs consistent with a rapid fossil-fuel phase-out.
- (ii) Tie Niger's support to scaled-up adaptation finance with simplified access for LDCs.
- (iii) Use the Loss and Damage Fund, with the African Group and the LDC Group.

4. Confidence and limits

Heat projections are robust in direction but wide in size (59 to 134 days in 2100). The drought indicator saturates, and the tool does not model millet or sorghum. These are hazard projections, not forecasts; given Niger's vulnerability, real impacts are likely to be larger.

References

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